

And may their sons become many and great beyond the stars of heaven,

And their numbers be more than the sand of the sea.

17. And may He give them this goodly land—as He said He would give it to Abraham and to his seed after him always—

And may they hold it as a possession for ever.

18. And may I see (born) unto thee, my son, blessed children during my life,

And a blessed and holy seed may all thy seed be.

19. And as thou hast refreshed thy mother's spirit during †my† life,

The womb of her that bare thee blesses thee,

[My affection] and my breasts bless thee

And my mouth and my tongue praise thee greatly.

20. Increase and spread over the earth,

And may thy seed be perfect in the joy of heaven and earth for ever ;

And may thy seed rejoice,

And on the great day of peace may it have peace.

21. And may thy name and thy seed endure to all the ages,

And may the Most High God be their God,

And may the God of righteousness dwell with them,

And by them may His sanctuary be built unto all the ages.

both phrases cf. Deut. xxxiv. 9 "the spirit of wisdom" (רוח הכמה); Num. xi. 25, 26, 29; Neh. ix. 20; Is. xi. 2.

17. *As He said He would give it to Abraham and to his seed . . . always.* Cf. Luke i. 55, καθὼς ἐλάλησεν . . . τῷ Ἀβραάμ καὶ τῷ σπέρματι αὐτοῦ εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα. The words in Luke recall both Mic. vii. 20 and our text. Observe that this statement in Luke is added parenthetically or explanatorily as in our text.

*Possession for ever.* Cf. the Thucydidean phrase κτήμα ἐς αἰ.

19. *Hast refreshed (ab).* *cd* "has given thee rest."

†*My*†. Read "thy," as the sense requires it.

[*My affection*]. I have bracketed this phrase; for it comes in awkwardly between "womb," "breasts," "mouth," and "tongue." We should expect an "and" to precede it. It may be a dittography and have originated as a false alternative rendering of רֶחֶם, "womb."

21. *His sanctuary . . . unto all the ages.* Cf. i. 29.